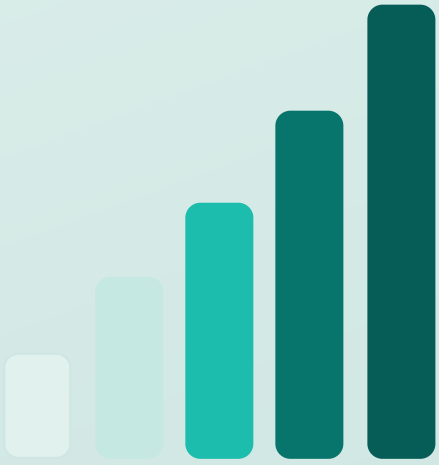
/ ignis

WHITE PAPER · CONTRACTING TO CLOSE

How to build a commercial system for your pipeline

Why supplier comparison, contract terms and the close file have to be one record if the next project is to start where the last one finished.

Yorik Tisseau · Ignis Leadership · October 2026



UK and European solar, wind and BESS

ABSTRACT

A solar, wind or battery project does not reach financial close because someone worked harder on the last draft. It reaches close because the supplier comparison, the contract and the lender pack describe the same project. That is harder than it sounds.

This paper argues that the binding constraint is no longer finding another project. It is keeping one commercial record from the grid offer to signature. The evidence for delivery, resilience and sustainability is the same evidence the EPC contract and the close file have to carry.

In Great Britain the revenue case is still a chain of public prices. AR7a solar cleared at £65.23/MWh against a £75 cap, and the 2029/30 Capacity Market T-4 cleared at £27.10/kW/year. In the European Union, from 30 December 2025, renewable auctions have to apply non-price criteria to at least 30% of the volume auctioned each year, or to at least 6 GW. Where those criteria are used to award a contract, the price weighs 70–85% and the non-price factors 15–30%.

The next project should start from that record, rather than from a blank folder. The figures use public sources. The worked 60 MW example is labelled as illustrative wherever an assumption is ours.

KEY FINDINGS

1

European auctions now score evidence, not only price.

From 30 December 2025, Article 26 of the Net-Zero Industry Act applies non-price criteria to at least 30% of auctioned renewable volume a year, or 6 GW. Pre-qualification covers responsible business conduct, cybersecurity and the ability to deliver. As award criteria, price weighs 70–85% and non-price factors 15–30%, with each non-price criterion at least 5%. [1] [2] [3]

2

GB revenue is still a chain of published prices.

AR7a awarded 4.9 GW of solar at £65.23/MWh, 13% under the £75 administrative strike price that AR8 keeps. The 2029/30 T-4 Capacity Market cleared at £27.10/kW/year, down from £60. A contract that ignores either number will not match the model. [5] [6] [7]

3

The grid date has become a contract date.

Connections reform cut a queue of over 700 GW to a 283 GW pipeline. A Gate 2 transmission offer has to be signed within 90 days. The date in that offer has to be the date in the offtake, the EPC programme and the close file. [8] [9]

4

The file breaks between comparison and signature.

Capacity, price and dates drift across the supplier packs, the model, the draft contract and the lender questions. There is no public dataset of those hours. The pattern is the same on every live project we see: senior people reconcile versions instead of deciding.

5

One pound and one year are the decisions that matter.

On an illustrative 60 MW solar project at an 11% load factor, £1/MWh is about £58,000 a year. A one-year slip at the AR7a clearing price defers about £3.8 million of revenue. Those calls belong in the comparison, not in the week of signing.

KEY TERMS

Commercial system
The process, context, data, governance and workflows that carry one project from grid offer to financial close, and leave a record the next project can use.

Non-price criteria
Auction tests other than price. Under the EU Net-Zero Industry Act they include delivery, cybersecurity, responsible business conduct, resilience and sustainability. [1]

Comparison file
The single view of supplier offers against the same scope, programme, price and risk, with every difference written down before a contract is drafted.

Close file
The pack a lender, buyer or board uses at financial close. It has to match the comparison and the signed terms, not a parallel spreadsheet.

Gate 2
The stage of GB connections reform at which a project that is ready receives a firm connection offer and a date. Transmission offers are signed within 90 days. [9]

Administrative strike price
The maximum CfD strike price a technology can receive. For solar it is £75/MWh in 2024 prices in both AR7 and AR8. [6]

1 · THE LANDSCAPE

What has to be true between the tender and financial close?

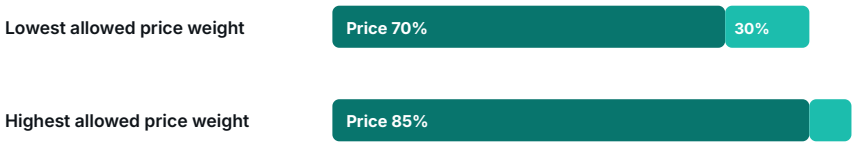
SHORT ANSWER

The same project, described once. In the EU that description now includes scored evidence as well as a price. In Great Britain it includes a clearing price, a capacity payment and a grid date. If those live in different files, the close is a reconciliation exercise.

Europe: price is no longer the whole award

Article 26 of the Net-Zero Industry Act requires Member States to apply specified non-price criteria in auctions for renewable energy. The Commission's guidance, published in 2026, states that this applies from 30 December 2025 to at least 30% of the volume auctioned per year in each Member State, or alternatively to at least 6 GW a year. The volume is the capacity or generation the auction is designed to support, counted across technologies, and it counts in the year the auction is published rather than the year the result is announced. [1] [2] [4]

Responsible business conduct, cybersecurity and the ability to deliver on time are pre-qualification. A project that fails them does not bid. Resilience and a sustainability criterion may be pre-qualification, award criteria, or both. Ireland's consultation on Article 26 states the award weighting directly: price must weigh 70–85%, non-price factors 15–30%, and each non-price award criterion at least 5%. [3] Member States still choose the detailed tests, so the same plant can face two evidence lists.



Non-price share is 30% at the low price weight and 15% at the high. Each non-price award criterion is at least 5%.

FIGURE 1

Where non-price criteria are used to award, price is 70–85% of the score

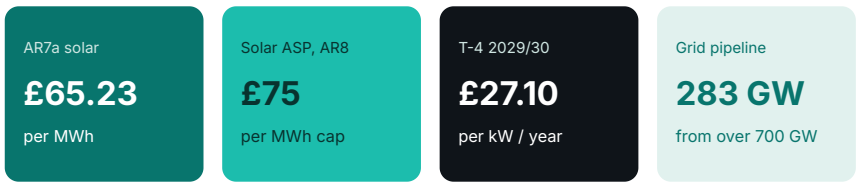
Award weighting described in Ireland's consultation on Article 26. The Commission guidance confirms the 30% or 6 GW coverage rule from 30 December 2025. Source: Government of Ireland consultation; European Commission guidance. [1] [3]

Great Britain: the price is public, and so is the date

GB CfD rounds remain pay-as-clear price auctions. AR7a awarded 4,905 MW of solar across 157 projects at £65.23/MWh in 2024 prices, against an administrative strike price of £75. Onshore wind cleared at £72.24 against £92. AR8 keeps those caps, puts solar in its own pot, and gives government sight of anonymised bids before budgets are set. [5] [6] A supplier comparison that prices a plant as if the cap were the revenue will not survive the model.

Battery revenue has a second public anchor. The 2029/30 T-4 Capacity Market cleared at £27.10/kW/year, less than half the £60 of the previous T-4. [7] A floor or toll can sit on top of that, but the capacity payment in the close file has to be the payment the auction actually produced, not last year's.

The grid queue is no longer a waiting room. NESO replaced a first-come queue of over 700 GW with a 283 GW pipeline of generation and storage. A Gate 2 transmission offer is signed within 90 days. [8] [9] That date is an input to the offtake, the EPC programme and the financing case. If the comparison uses a different date, the contract is already wrong.



2024 prices for the CfD figures. The Capacity Market price is nominal £/kW/year. The pipeline is generation and storage.

FIGURE 2

Four public numbers a contract has to be able to carry

Public anchors for a GB contract. Source: DESNZ AR7a results and AR8 Price and Pot Notice; Ofgem Capacity Market report 2025/26; NESO, 8 December 2025. [5] [6] [7] [8]

A developer active in both markets has two scoring systems and one plant. The EU bid needs evidence of delivery and resilience. The GB bid needs a price that can clear, a capacity case and a connection date. The supplier comparison under both has to use the same scope, programme and exclusions. That discipline is the commercial system.

---

2 · WHERE THE FILE BREAKS

Why does the close rebuild the comparison?

> **SHORT ANSWER**
> Because the comparison, the contract and the close file are usually three pieces of work, done by overlapping people, from exports that are already out of date. The deal still signs. The memory does not travel.

There is no public dataset of commercial hours on European or UK renewable projects, so this section is analysis, not a measurement. It draws on how the auctions above are structured and on Ignis practitioner experience of live projects. We see the same five breaks.

1

Offers that are not the same offer

Two suppliers answer the same tender and still price different interfaces, spares, weather risk and commissioning tests. The comparison looks like a price ranking. It is a scope ranking that has not been written down.

COST A cheap offer that becomes expensive once the gaps are contracted

2

A model that is not the contract

Capex, indexation and the programme in the financial model are a week behind the draft the supplier is marking up. The board approves one case. The signature page records another.

COST A return that was never in the document being signed

3

Dates that do not agree

The grid offer, the offtake longstop and the EPC programme each carry a date. They are updated in different inboxes. Nobody owns the difference.

COST Delay damages, a missed delivery year, or a lender condition that arrives late

4

Evidence scored twice, stored nowhere

An EU auction asks for delivery evidence and a resilience statement. The same facts are rebuilt for the EPC tender and again for the lender. Nothing is filed as the version that won.

COST Weeks of senior time, and a close question the team cannot answer from the record

5

The next project starts blank

The negotiation that protected margin on the last plant sits in a markup and a memory. The next tender does not inherit the clause, the exclusion or the reason it mattered.

COST The same point conceded again, at the same point in the programme

The people who can see these breaks are the same people needed to decide them: the commercial lead, the technical lead and whoever will sign. Their weeks go on version control. The calls that move the deal, margin, risk and the terms that will still be true at close, get whatever time is left. A commercial system reverses that order. Agents can chase the versions and draft the first comparison. A named person still decides the price, the risk and the term.

---

3 · THE SYSTEM

What are the five layers between grid offer and close?

> **SHORT ANSWER**
> Process, context, data, governance and workflows. They are not a software catalogue. They are the minimum that lets the next project start where the last one finished.

Ignis sets these five layers up on the client's own evidence. The descriptions below are the ones we use on the site, because they are also the ones a close has to satisfy. Nothing here requires a rip-and-replace of the model, the data room or the contract tool. It requires that those tools stop being the only place a number can live.

FIGURE 3

Five layers, one record

01	Process	WHAT IT HOLDS How each project moves from grid offer to close.
02	Context	WHAT IT HOLDS Your past projects, plus market, policy and commercial knowledge.
03	Data	WHAT IT HOLDS One trusted set of numbers across the pipeline.
04	Governance	WHAT IT HOLDS Approvals, controls and a full audit trail.
05	Workflows	WHAT IT HOLDS Repeatable commercial work, run by agents.

The same five layers apply to an onshore solar or battery project and to offshore wind. The documents change. The record does not. Source: Ignis.

What each layer does on a live contract

Process is the path the team already walks, written down: grid offer, consents, supplier tender, comparison, negotiation, offtake, due diligence, contracts, financial close. Each step has an owner and a definition of done. Without that, an agent will automate whatever version of the path lives in one person's head.

Context is the memory. Past comparisons, the clauses that were conceded, the exclusions that turned out to matter, and the public rules the current deal has to meet: a CfD cap, a Capacity Market price, an EU non-price test, a Gate 2 deadline. Context is not a dump of old files. It is the set a person is prepared to rely on.

Data is the single set of numbers. Capacity, dates, price, indexation and scope. The tender, the model, the contract and the close file read from it. When a number changes, the other documents are flagged, not quietly edited. This is the layer that stops a 49.9 MW plant becoming 50 MW in one pack and 48 MW in another.

Governance is who may change a price, accept a risk or send a mark-up. The approval sits on the record with the evidence that was in front of the person who gave it. A full audit trail is what a lender asks for when two drafts disagree, and what a board needs when it asks why this term was accepted.

Workflows are the repeatable work: building the comparison grid, chasing missing interface schedules, drafting the first mark-up against the last agreed position, checking that dates match. Agents can run that work. They stop at the decision. The person who owns margin, risk or a binding term still makes the call.

What stays human

The walk-away price, the risk the company will actually carry, the interface it will not accept, and the signature. An agent can show the difference between two offers. It does not choose which difference the company will live with for twenty years.

The comparison that closed the last project becomes the starting point for the next tender. The team spends the new project on what changed.

4 · WORKED EXAMPLE

What is a contract decision worth before anyone signs?

SHORT ANSWER

On an illustrative 60 MW solar plant, £1/MWh is about £58,000 a year and about £0.6 million in present value over a 20-year CfD. A one-year slip at the AR7a price defers about £3.8 million. The comparison should be organised around those decisions, not around the length of the draft.

The example is hypothetical. It is a 60 MW solar project with an illustrative 11% load factor, considering a CfD at the AR7a clearing price, an EPC comparison, and a co-located 30 MW battery that might enter the Capacity Market. Public numbers are the price anchors. Everything else is an assumption and is marked as such. We do not use a market EPC price, because we are not publishing one. The point of the tables is the order of magnitude, so a team can see which decisions deserve senior time.

TABLE 1 ILLUSTRATIVE

Worked example inputs

INPUT	VALUE	BASIS
Solar capacity	60 MW	Illustrative assumption
Load factor	11%, with a 10–12% range	Illustrative assumption
Annual generation at 11%	57,816 MWh	60 × 8,760 × 11%
Revenue price	£65.23/MWh, 2024 prices	AR7a solar clearing price [5]
Price cap	£75/MWh, 2024 prices	Solar administrative strike price, kept for AR8 [6]
Contract length for the present-value line	20 years	CfD length for solar from AR7 [5]
Discount rate	7% real	Illustrative assumption
Battery used only for the capacity line	30 MW, 21% de-rating	Illustrative assumption
Capacity payment	£27.10/kW/year	T-4 delivery year 2029/30 [7]

Generation is alternating-current capacity times hours times load factor. Present value uses a 20-year annuity at 7%, factor 10.59.
Source: public anchors as cited. All other values are Ignis assumptions.

TABLE 2 ILLUSTRATIVE

Annual solar revenue by price and load factor (£ million, 2024 prices)

LOAD FACTOR	£60/MWH	£65.23/MWH	£70/MWH	£75/MWH CAP
10%	3.15	3.43	3.68	3.94
11%	3.47	3.77	4.05	4.34
12%	3.78	4.11	4.42	4.73

A one-point error in yield moves annual revenue by about as much as a £6/MWh move in price. Yield evidence belongs in the comparison with the same status as the contract price. Source: Ignis calculation, generation × price. Excludes indexation, curtailment and negative-price rules.

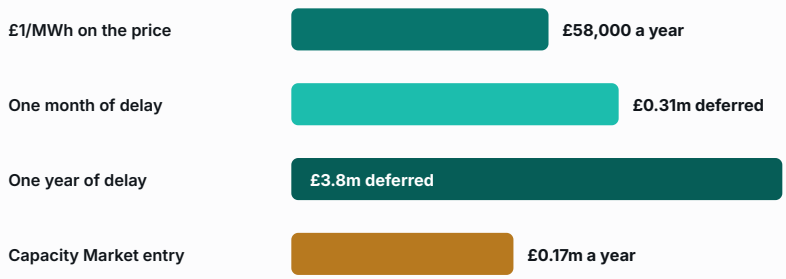


FIGURE 4

What a contract decision is worth

£58,000 is 57,816 MWh × £1. The present value of that pound over 20 years at 7% is about £0.61 million. A year of delay defers 57,816 × £65.23. A month is that figure divided by 12. The Capacity Market line is 30 MW × 21% × £27.10/kW. Source: Ignis illustrative calculation from Table 1 and the public prices in sources 5 and 7.

Read the figure from the top. A negotiation that gives away £1/MWh to close a point of interface risk has a price. So does a programme that slips a month because an exclusion was never aligned with the grid date. The Capacity Market line is smaller than a year of solar revenue, which is the point of putting the numbers in one place: the team can see which argument is worth the week.

The same arithmetic is what a European non-price score is competing with. If 15–30% of an award is evidence rather than price, the comparison has to show whether the supplier can actually produce that evidence, not only whether the headline is lower. A resilience statement that the EPC contract then contradicts is not a scoring advantage. It is a close problem waiting for the lender.

TABLE 3

What has to agree before signature

ITEM	COMPARISON	CONTRACT	CLOSE FILE
Capacity and interface point	Same scope for every offer	Same scope, with exclusions listed	Same capacity as the model
Price and indexation	Offers restated onto one index	The agreed price, not the first quote	The price the board approved
Programme and grid date	Each offer against the connection date	Longstop tied to that date	The date in the offer that was signed
Evidence for non-price tests	Which offer can support the score	Obligations that keep the evidence true	The pack the auction and the lender both see
Open risks	Written, with an owner	Allocated, or still open on purpose	The same list, not a new one

If a cell cannot be filled from the record, the close is still rebuilding the comparison. Source: Ignis.

5 · IMPLICATIONS

What should a developer do before the next close?

SHORT ANSWER

Put the live project on one record before the next supplier comparison. Decide the walk-away with the public price and the grid date in view. Make the comparison the source the contract and the close file have to match. Keep the decisions, and use agents for the chasing and the first draft.

1. **Name the path.** Write the steps from the current gate to financial close, and the person who owns each one. If two people think a step ends in different documents, that is the first fix.
2. **Restate every offer onto one scope.** Do not rank prices until interfaces, exclusions, indexation and the programme are on the same lines. The ranking is a decision. The restatement can be drafted by an agent and checked by the technical lead.
3. **Lock the numbers that are already public.** The CfD cap, the last clearing price, the Capacity Market result and the connection date are not opinions. They go in the data layer and the model reads them.
4. **Approve changes, do not email them.** A price, a date or a risk allocation changes only with a named approval. The previous value stays visible. That is the audit trail a close question will ask for.
5. **Leave the record where the next project can find it.** The comparison, the rejected clause and the reason are context. The next tender starts there. Ignis is built to hold that record on your evidence, with agents doing the repeatable work and your team keeping the calls.

Investors do not need another narrative of how busy the tender was. They need to see why this price, this date and this risk were accepted, and that the signed contract is the one the model describes. That is a commercial system. The alternative is to rebuild it, project by project, until the pipeline is limited by memory rather than by sites.

6 · METHOD AND SOURCES

How was this analysis done?

> **SHORT ANSWER**
> From public EU and UK sources, read in October 2026, plus an illustrative calculation whose assumptions are in Table 1. Where no public series exists, the paper says so.

Rules and prices. The Net-Zero Industry Act coverage rule is taken from the Commission guidance of 2026 and the Commission's own description of the support-scheme rules, with the implementing regulation as further context. The 70–85% and 15–30% award weights, and the 5% minimum per non-price criterion, are taken from the Government of Ireland's consultation describing Article 26, not from a claim that every Member State has already published identical scoring. GB prices are from the DESNZ AR7a results, the AR8 Price and Pot Notice, and Ofgem's Capacity Market report for 2025/26. The grid figures are from NESO's December 2025 releases and the connections handbook.

Illustrative calculation. Figure 4 and Tables 1 and 2 use a hypothetical 60 MW plant. Load factor, discount rate, battery size and de-rating are assumptions. The arithmetic is generation times price, a 20-year annuity at 7% (factor 10.59), and a one-twelfth split for a month of delay. They are not a forecast and they are not a measured project.

What this paper does not do. It does not report client results, quote a developer, or invent an EPC market price. It does not claim that Ignis has changed a close outcome. The Ignis system is the record described in section 3. Performance claims would need a measured project, and this paper does not contain one.

Not covered. A full legal reading of every national auction, corporate PPA pricing, and offshore wind CfD pots. The companion paper, Bids are now won on evidence, not hours, treats the bid desk. This one treats the path from comparison to close.

APPENDIX

Is the commercial record ready for the next project?

> **SHORT ANSWER**
> Score eight statements. Seven or more means the next project can start from the last one. Three or fewer means the first job is a single evidence library, before any more drafting.

- ☐ The path from grid offer to close is written down, with an owner for each step.
- ☐ Supplier offers are restated onto one scope before they are ranked.
- ☐ Capacity, price and dates exist once, and the model reads that set.
- ☐ The connection date in the contract is the date in the grid offer.
- ☐ A price or a risk changes only with a named approval on the record.
- ☐ Non-price evidence for an EU bid is the same evidence the contract relies on.
- ☐ The close file is checked against the comparison before it goes to a lender.
- ☐ The last project's comparison and rejected terms are where the next tender starts.

7–8	4–6	0–3
Ready for the next project	Fix the gaps before the next close	Start with one evidence library

Questions for the next comparison

1. Which numbers in the live offers are not yet the numbers in the model?
2. Which date is the connection date, and which drafts still use another?
3. Which exclusions change the price by more than the point we would negotiate?
4. What did we refuse on the last project, and is that position in this draft?
5. Who approves the walk-away, and where will that approval sit?

Sources

1 European Commission, guidance on non-price criteria under Article 26 of the Net-Zero Industry Act (2026). eur-lex.europa.eu

2 European Commission, support schemes for renewable energy, Net-Zero Industry Act summary. energy.ec.europa.eu

3 Government of Ireland, consultation on Article 26 of the Net-Zero Industry Act. www.gov.ie

4 Commission Implementing Regulation (EU) 2025/1176. eur-lex.europa.eu

5 DESNZ, Contracts for Difference Allocation Round 7a results (10 February 2026). assets.publishing.service.gov.uk

6 DESNZ, CfD Allocation Round 8 Price and Pot Notice. assets.publishing.service.gov.uk

7 Ofgem, annual report on the operation of the Capacity Market in 2025/26. www.ofgem.gov.uk

8 NESO, unveiling the new project pipeline to deliver clean power by 2030 (8 December 2025). www.neso.energy

9 NESO, Connections Reform customer handbook. www.neso.energy